Lab: Pattern Design Workshop — Counting Stitches, Noticing Drift

Objective

Develop awareness of your perceptual processes during crochet by systematically observing, measuring, and tracking how you gather information from your work-in-progress.

Materials Needed

- A simple crochet pattern (flat rectangular project recommended — dishcloth or scarf)
- Appropriate hook and yarn
- Stitch markers (at least 10)
- Ruler or tape measure
- Journal or notebook
- Timer

Exercise 1: Perceptual Channel Inventory (20 minutes)

Work 5 rows of your pattern. After each row, pause and record in your journal every piece of information you gathered while working, organized by sensory channel:

Channel	What I Noticed	How Precise? (1-5)
Visual	(e.g., stitch alignment, color consistency)	
Tactile	(e.g., yarn tension, fabric density)	
Proprioceptive	(e.g., hand position, hook angle)	
Auditory	(e.g., yarn sliding, hook clicking)	
Gestalt/Intuitive	(e.g., "this feels right," "something is off")	

After 5 rows, review: Which channels do you use most? Which are most precise? Are there channels you barely noticed using?

Exercise 2: Stitch Count Tracking (30 minutes)

Work 10 rows of your pattern, counting stitches at the end of every row. Record:

Row	Expected Count	Actual Count	Match?	How I Detected Mismatch	Time to Count
1					
2					
...					

Now work 10 more rows, but only count every 5th row. Instead, rely on visual impression for the non-counted rows.

Compare: Did your non-counted rows accumulate errors that the counted rows caught? How accurate was your visual impression compared to actual counting? What does this tell you about the precision difference between these two perceptual strategies?

Exercise 3: Detecting Drift (30 minutes)

Intentionally create drift in a test swatch:

1. Chain 25 and work 5 rows of single crochet at your normal tension
2. For the next 5 rows, gradually increase your tension (pull yarn tighter)
3. For the next 5 rows, gradually relax your tension (work looser)
4. Measure the width of your piece at rows 5, 10, and 15

Questions: - At what point did you visually notice the tension change? - How many rows of drift occurred before it became perceptible? - Measure the difference in width — how many stitches of difference does the drift represent? - If you were not deliberately creating the drift, would you have caught it? When?

Exercise 4: Stitch Marker Experiment (20 minutes)

Work a row of 30 stitches two ways:

1. **Without markers**: Work the row, then count to verify
2. **With markers every 10 stitches**: Place a marker after stitch 10, stitch 20, and verify each section separately

Compare: - Which method was faster? - Which method was more accurate? - How did the markers change your perceptual experience? Did they create "checkpoints" that broke the counting task into smaller, more manageable state estimates?

Exercise 5: Gauge Perception Lab (20 minutes)

Make a gauge swatch of at least 5 x 5 inches. Then measure gauge in three ways:

1. **Casual**: Hold the swatch up and estimate stitches per inch by eyeballing
2. **Standard**: Lay flat, use ruler, count stitches in 4 inches
3. **Precise**: Pin to blocking board, count stitches in 4 inches at three different locations

Record your three measurements. How much do they differ? What does this reveal about how measurement method affects the precision of your perceptual data?

Discussion Questions for the Circle

1. Do you tend to trust your counting (high precision) or your visual impression (gestalt) more? Has this ever led you astray?
2. Have you ever experienced tension drift without noticing until many rows later? How did you detect it, and what did you do?
3. How do you decide how often to count stitches? Is there a strategy, or do you follow gut feeling?

Wrap-Up

Write a brief reflection (3-5 sentences) on what you learned about your own perceptual processes while crocheting. Did any observations surprise you? How might you change your approach to monitoring your work?